ANDHRA PRADESH

FLOOD OF NEGLECT

By Amarnath K. Menon



EMPATHY VISIT Andhra Pradesh CM Chandrababu Naidu meets flood victims in Vijayawada, Sept. 3

The devastating floods that submerged half of the 64 municipal divisions in Vijayawada in early September were largely a man-made disaster, say experts. Unbridled urbanisation along with delayed and non-existent flood mitigation measures combined to make it a nightmarish experience for residents. As water levels in the Krishna river rose in the wake of incessant rains through August 31 and September 1, when 27 per cent of the annual average rain fell in 48 hours, many buildings along the river were submerged, forcing residents to shift to safer places. But the real cause of the devastation was the swollen Budameru stream, flowing through Vijayawada, which speedily swamped low-lying colonies. Andhra Pradesh chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu moved in to survey the situation, camping in a bus parked in the compound of the NTR District Collector's Office in Vijayawada. Until the flood waters receded and power and piped water in large parts of the city was restored on September 10, Naidu ran his government from there. The chief minister himself was affected too—the Krishna flood waters submerged the ground floor of his home at Undavalli, in the Andhra Pradesh capital region of Amaravati.

Budameru originates in the Khammam district of Telangana, flows through the NTR district of Andhra, before draining into Kolleru lake in Eluru district. Kolleru is connected to the Bay of Bengal through the Upputeru river. Along its path, excess water from agricultural fields and streams flows into the Budameru, making it a vital water channel and, traditionally, a cause of floods in monsoon months. However, encroachment along its entire route disrupts its natural flow and hampers flood management.

Over the past five decades, thousands have made the Budameru bunds their homes, constructing makeshift and permanent structures. This constriction of the Budameru is the main reason for the floods in the Vijayawada region. Through its course in Vijayawada, the Budameru can carry only one-sixth of the originally intended flow of water. Therefore, during the heavy rainfall event, it just overflowed its banks, causing mayhem. Successive governments have failed to remove encroachments and focus on a Budameru modernisation plan.

Naidu claimed that it was the apathy of the previous Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) government that had resulted in the calamity, affecting the lives of over 230,000 families. Vowing to extend every help to flood victims, the CM resolved to start 'Operation Budameru' to desilt the channel and clear illegal encroachments, which he alleged were encouraged by the

SUFFOCATING NATURE

- **The flood in Vijayawada was caused when the Budameru rivulet, flowing through the city, burst its banks after heavy rains**
- **Over the decades, reckless human encroachment has choked the flood-prone river**
- **The solution is to expand Budameru Diversion Channel; merging the river with the Krishna below Prakasam barrage**